A PARENT'S TOOLKIT

Gentle Parenting, Rewired

Calm, practical tools for ADHD & autistic kids

Scripts · Routines · Sensory tools · Printables

WELCOME

Hi, parent.
You're in the right place.

Raising a child whose brain works differently takes love, patience and a lot of improvising. Gentle parenting asks for connection, respect and empathy, and that is a great foundation. But much of the standard advice quietly assumes a neurotypical child. This toolkit closes that gap with tools built for ADHD and autistic brains.

How to use this guide

1 Skim

Read the Big 5 principles on page 6. They shape everything else.

2 Pick one

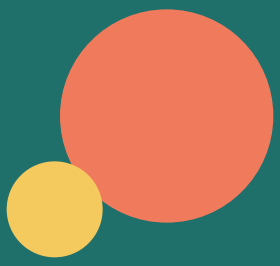
Choose one tool for your hardest time of day. Start tiny.

3 Print

Use the worksheets on pages 13 to 15 and fill them in together.

Behavior is communication.

Behind most "won't" is a "can't yet". When we treat challenges as missing skills or unmet needs instead of defiance, gentle parenting finally fits. That one shift is the heart of this guide.



A quick note on language

We use "autistic" and "ADHD" plainly and respectfully, and many children are both. Every child is different, so treat this guide as a menu, not a rulebook. It offers general parenting information and is not medical advice. Talk to your child's clinician about diagnosis or treatment.

INSIDE

What's inside

01	Why gentle parenting needs an upgrade	4
02	Brains at a glance	5
03	The Big 5 principles	6
04	Meltdowns & shutdowns	7
05	The sensory toolkit	8
06	Routines & transitions	9
07	Say this, not that	10
08	Daily flashpoints	11
09	Boundaries that stay gentle	12
10	Printables: calm plan, sensory profile, day plan	13–15
11	Caring for you	16
12	Your 30-day starter plan	17

CHAPTER 01

Why gentle parenting needs an upgrade

The values stay the same: connection, respect, empathy. What changes is the delivery. Here is where common advice trips up neurodivergent kids, and what to do instead.

WHAT THE BOOKS SAY	THE UPGRADE
"Talk it through when they're upset."	Stay close and quiet first. Talk later, once the body is calm.
"Give lots of choices."	Offer two clear choices. Open-ended options can freeze a brain that struggles to decide.
"Use time-out to reflect."	Offer a calm-down space they help choose. It is comfort, never punishment.
"Explain the why."	Keep words short. Show it with pictures, timers and examples.
"Praise good behavior."	Name effort specifically: "You stopped and took a breath."
"Expect eye contact and a listening face."	Let them fidget, stim and look away. Listening doesn't look one way.

Same heart. Different delivery.

You're not abandoning gentle parenting. You're making it fit your child's brain.

CHAPTER 02

Brains at a glance

A quick, strengths-based snapshot. Use it to guess what's behind a behavior, then check with your child.

ADHD

STRENGTHS

- Creative, energetic and curious
- Big-picture and fast ideas
- Intense focus on what excites them

COMMON CHALLENGES

- Time blindness
- Starting and finishing tasks
- Big, fast emotions
- Impulse control and working memory
- Sensitivity to criticism

WHAT HELPS

- Movement built into the day
- Visual timers and short tasks
- Quick, specific feedback
- A buddy nearby (body doubling)
- Interest-based motivation

Autism

STRENGTHS

- Deep focus and expertise
- Pattern spotting and honesty
- Strong memory and loyalty

COMMON CHALLENGES

- Sensory overload
- Sudden changes and surprises
- Literal reading of language
- Social energy runs out fast
- Unwritten social rules

WHAT HELPS

- Predictability and advance notice
- Clear, literal, short language
- Planned sensory breaks
- Alone time to recharge
- Respect for special interests

Many children are both. Autism and ADHD often overlap, so mix and match. Follow your child, not the label.

CHAPTER 03

The Big 5 principles

If you remember nothing else, remember these five. Every tool in this guide grows from them.

1

Regulate, then relate

A dysregulated brain can't learn. Calm the body first: lower your voice, lower the lights, lower the demands.

2

Connection before correction

Get close, get curious, then guide. Correction only lands when a child feels safe with you.

3

Make it visible

Pictures, timers, checklists and first/then boards. Spoken words vanish; visuals stay put.

4

Reduce the load

Fewer steps, fewer words, fewer surprises. Trim demands until success is likely.

5

Follow the interest

Special interests are bridges, not distractions. Use them to teach, motivate and connect.

CHAPTER 04

Meltdowns & shutdowns

Big reactions look similar from the outside but have different causes. Knowing which one you're seeing changes your response.

TANTRUM

Tied to a want or a need.

Your child keeps some control and may check how you react. It usually eases once the need is met or the moment passes.

MELTDOWN

Overload spilling out.

Not a choice and not manipulation. Can't be stopped on demand. May look like crying, yelling, running or lashing out.

SHUTDOWN

Overload turned inward.

Quiet, withdrawn, frozen or unable to speak. Easy to miss, and just as real.

The 5-step calm response

1. **Pause and breathe**
   You first. Slow your breath and drop your shoulders. Your calm is contagious.
2. **Make it safe**
   Move hazards, dim lights, reduce noise, give space. Stay close but don't crowd.
3. **Use very few words**
   "I'm here. You're safe." Then quiet. No questions, lectures or bargaining.
4. **Wait it out**
   Let them stim, hide or rock. Offer water or a comfort item. No consequences mid-storm.
5. **Reconnect later**
   When calm, offer a snack and a hug if wanted. Problem-solve together, with drawing or choices if talking is hard.

Storm warnings: covering ears, pacing, getting louder or very quiet, rigid body, more stimming, snapping at small things. Act early: reduce demands and offer a break.

CHAPTER 05

The sensory toolkit

Sensory needs are real needs. Many kids seek some input and avoid other input. Try, watch, adjust.

Sound

- Noise-reducing headphones or ear defenders
- A quiet corner at home
- Warn before loud things (vacuum, hand dryer)
- Familiar music or white noise

Light & sight

- Lamps instead of harsh overhead lights
- Sunglasses or a cap indoors
- Less visual clutter
- Screen breaks and brightness down

Touch & clothes

- Tagless, soft, seamless clothing
- Cut out itchy labels
- Deep-pressure hugs, only if invited
- Fidgets with favorite textures

Movement

- Trampoline, swing or wall push-ups
- “Heavy work”: carry groceries, push a cart
- Chew-safe tools or crunchy snacks
- Short walks between tasks

Smell & taste

- Skip strong scents (perfume, cleaners)
- Keep a safe food on the table
- No pressure for “just one bite”
- Offer crunchy or chewy options

Social energy

- Alone time after school
- A “no talking” hour to recharge
- Permission to leave early
- Practice scripts for tough moments

Tip: Ask a clinician before using weighted items, and always let your child say no to touch.

CHAPTER 06

Routines & transitions

Stopping one thing and starting another is one of the hardest moves for both ADHD and autistic brains. Make the path visible.

Visual schedule

Photos or icons in order. Let your child move each one to “done”.

First / Then

“First shoes, then park.” Two steps, one reward. Clear and short.

Visual timers

Time you can see shrinking beats “five more minutes”. Try a sand or color timer.

Bridge objects

Let them carry a toy or snack to the next place so the change feels softer.

The transition ladder

10 min	5 min	1 min	NOW
“Ten minutes, then dinner.”	“Five minutes. Pick your last turn.”	“One minute. Start saving.”	“Time to go. Take your bridge toy.”

Beat time blindness

- Translate time into kid terms: “two songs long”, “one episode”.
- Turn chores into races against a visual timer, not against you.
- Build in buffer time. Everything takes longer than it looks.
- Give a heads-up before a change, and a reason when you can.

CHAPTER 07

Say this, not that

Short, calm, concrete words. Use these as starters, then make them sound like you.

INSTEAD OF	TRY
“Calm down!”	“I’m here. Let’s find your quiet spot.”
“Why did you do that?”	“That looked hard. What do you need?”
“Stop being dramatic.”	“Your feelings are big right now. I believe you.”
“Just focus.”	“Let’s make it smaller. What’s the first tiny step?”
“Look at me when I’m talking.”	“You can fidget. Tell me one thing you heard.”
“Use your words.”	“Show me, point, draw or type it. Any way works.”
“You should know better.”	“Let’s figure out what got in the way.”
“Hurry up, we’re late!”	“Leaving in 5 minutes. Shoes first, snack in the car.”

Tone beats script. Low voice, relaxed face, few words. If you flub it, try again later. Repair always counts.

CHAPTER 08

Daily flashpoints

The four times of day that most often go sideways, and what usually helps.

Mornings

The snag: Too many steps, plus time blindness.

TRY THIS

- Prep clothes and bag the night before
- Picture checklist by the door
- One instruction at a time
- Keep the first 10 minutes demand-free

Homework

The snag: Hard to start, tired after school.

TRY THIS

- Decompress 30–60 minutes first
- Work in 10–15 minute chunks
- Start with the easiest or most interesting task
- Sit nearby while they work

Mealtimes

The snag: Textures, smells and pressure.

TRY THIS

- Always serve one safe food
- Keep foods separate on the plate
- Drop the “one more bite” rule
- Allow a quieter seat or gentle movement

Bedtime

The snag: Busy brain, sensory needs, hard to wind down.

TRY THIS

- Same 3–4 step routine every night
- Dim lights an hour before
- Soft, familiar sensory comforts
- A “worry notebook” for racing thoughts

Ongoing sleep trouble? Check in with your child’s doctor before trying supplements or medication.

CHAPTER 09

Boundaries that stay gentle

Gentle is not permissive. Kids with big needs feel safest when limits are clear, calm and predictable.

1. Validate the feeling ▶ **2. Hold the limit** ▶ **3. Offer a way forward**

IN ACTION

"You really want more screen time. That's hard to stop. The timer is done. Do you want to stretch or have a snack?"

Four rules for limits that work

Few and clear

Pick the 3–5 rules that matter most.

Visible

Post them with words or pictures.

Say the do

"Feet on the floor" beats "stop climbing".

Same every time

Same limit, same calm, same follow-through.

Safety limits are non-negotiable

If someone could get hurt (running toward a road, hitting), calmly block and guide first. Skip the lecture. Talk it through later when everyone is regulated. Avoid taking away comfort items, movement or special interests as a punishment.

Repair is the real superpower.

"That was hard for both of us. I love you. Let's try again." Repairing a rough moment teaches more than never having one.

PRINTABLE 1

Our Calm Plan

Fill this out together when everyone is calm.

Name: _____ Date: _____

My body warns me when...

_____

_____

_____

What helps me calm down (tick all that help)

- ☐ Headphones
- ☐ Squeezing something
- ☐ Quiet and dim lights
- ☐ Jumping or moving
- ☐ Water or a snack
- ☐ Drawing or writing
- ☐ Favorite song or show
- ☐ A hug (if I ask)
- ☐ Under a blanket
- ☐ Fidget toy
- ☐ Talking later
- ☐ Counting breaths

Other: _____

My calm spot is...

draw or stick a photo here

These make it worse...

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

How my grown-ups can help...

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

Words that help me...

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

PRINTABLE 2

Sensory Profile

Notice, don't judge. Fill in over a week of watching.

SENSE	LOVES (seeks)	AVOIDS	WHAT HELPS
Sound *music, crowds, hand dryers*			
Sight *bright lights, clutter, screens*			
Touch *clothes tags, hugs, messy play*			
Movement *spinning, jumping, sitting still*			
Smell *perfume, cooking, cleaners*			
Taste & texture *crunchy, mushy, mixed foods*			

Tip: add stars to the three needs that cause the most trouble. Start your toolkit there.

PRINTABLE 3

My Day Plan

Draw or stick a picture in each box. Cross off as you go.

Name: _____ Day: _____

FIRST

THEN

Steps for today

1 ☐

picture

2 ☐

picture

3 ☐

picture

4 ☐

picture

5 ☐

picture

6 ☐

picture

WHEN I'M DONE I GET TO: _____

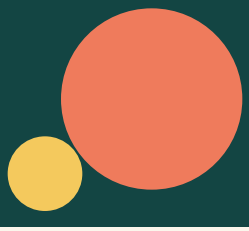
CHAPTER 10

Caring for you

Your calm is the most powerful tool in this toolkit, and it needs refilling too.

The pause pocket

Before you respond, ask:
Is my child safe? Am I calm enough? What does this need most?



Five small ways to refill

Lower the bar

Good enough is great. Skip the extras on hard days.

Make a parent calm plan

Know your own warning signs and your reset move, like water, a walk or music.

Find your people

Other parents of neurodivergent kids get it. Connection beats isolation.

Repair without guilt

You will snap sometimes. Apologize, reconnect, move on.

Celebrate tiny wins

“We left on time.” “We found the quiet spot.” Write them down.

Feeling overwhelmed or burnt out? Reach out to your doctor, a therapist or someone you trust. Needing support is not failing.

CHAPTER 11

Your 30-day starter plan

Small steps, one week at a time. Progress over perfection.

WEEK 1

Observe

Notice triggers and calm moments. Start the sensory profile (page 14).

WEEK 2

Prepare

Set up a visual schedule and a calm spot. Fill in the calm plan together.

WEEK 3

Practice

Pick three scripts. Use the 10-5-1 transition ladder every day.

WEEK 4

Refine

Keep what works. Drop what doesn't. Celebrate. Choose your next goal.

30 small wins tracker

Color in a circle every day you tried something, however small.

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
11	12	13	14	15	16	17	18	19	20
21	22	23	24	25	26	27	28	29	30

Reflect: What worked best? What will I try next month?

You've got this.

Your child doesn't need a perfect parent. They need a safe, steady one who keeps learning how their brain works. That's you.

PRINT IT. WRITE ON IT. MAKE IT YOURS.

This guide offers general parenting information only. It is not medical, psychological or legal advice. Please consult qualified professionals about your child's individual needs.